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(54) **COLLAPSIBLE SHIELDING DEVICE FOR
SMOKING ARTICLES AND METHOD
THEREFOR**

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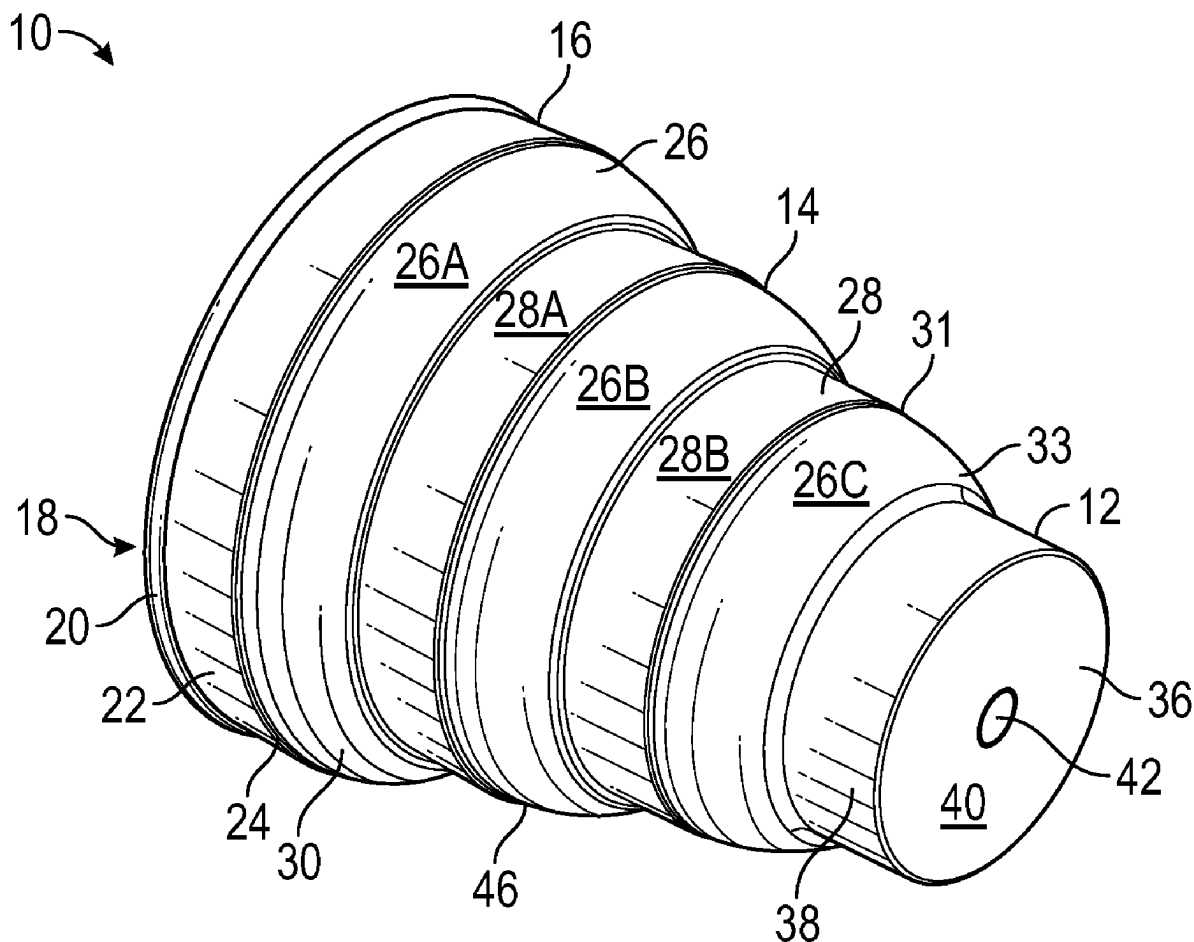
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(57) **ABSTRACT**

A collapsible shielding device for smoking articles comprises a top portion configured to receive at least a portion of smoking article therein, a bottom portion, and a body portion juxtaposed between the top portion and the bottom portion. The body portion includes a plurality of segments so that the device can be alternately configured in an extended orientation to shield a smoking article positioned therein and a compressed orientation to permit compact storage and ease of portability of the device when not in use.



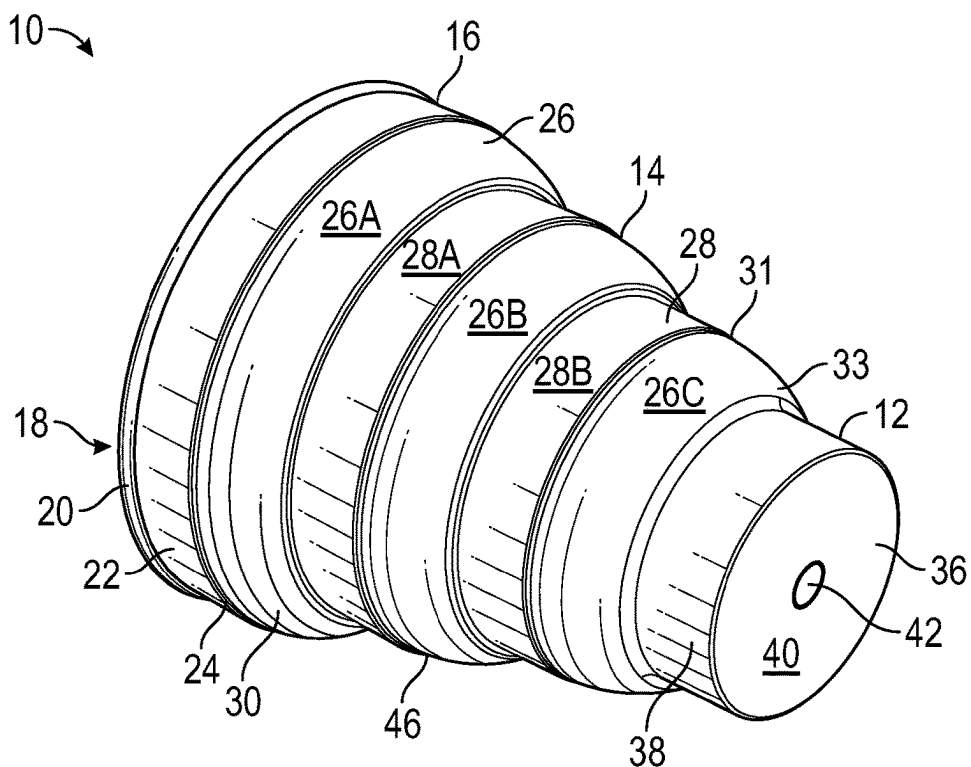


FIG. 1

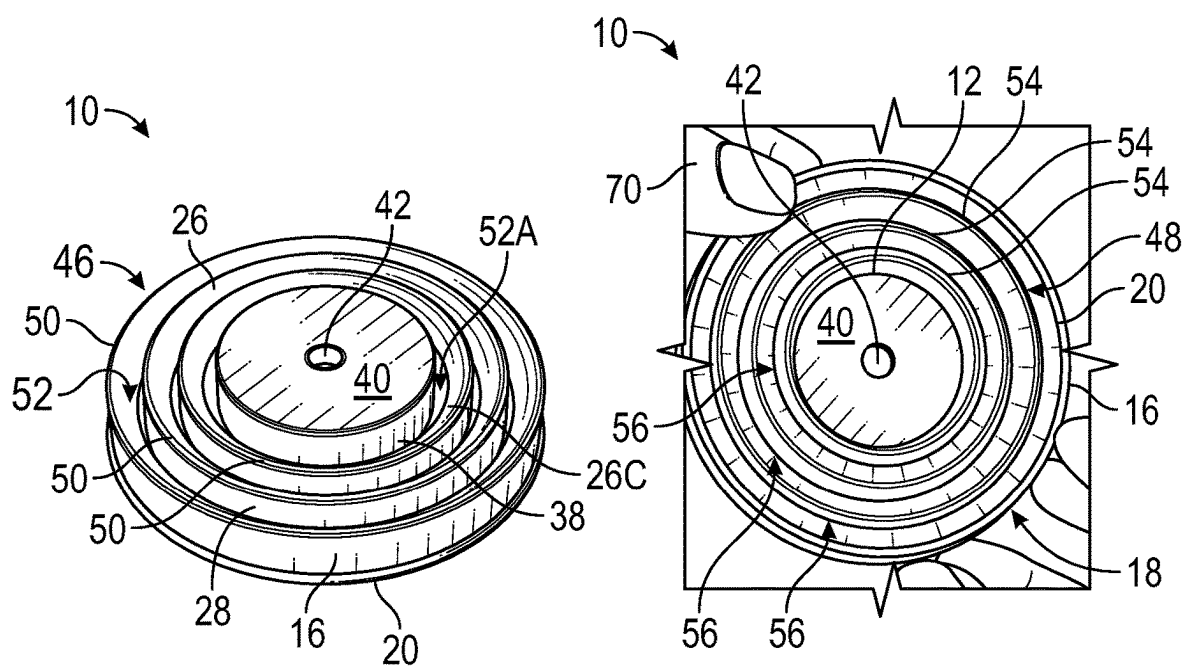


FIG. 2

FIG. 3

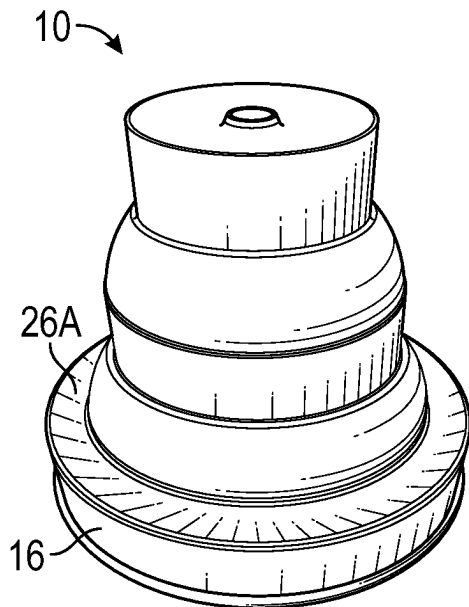


FIG. 4

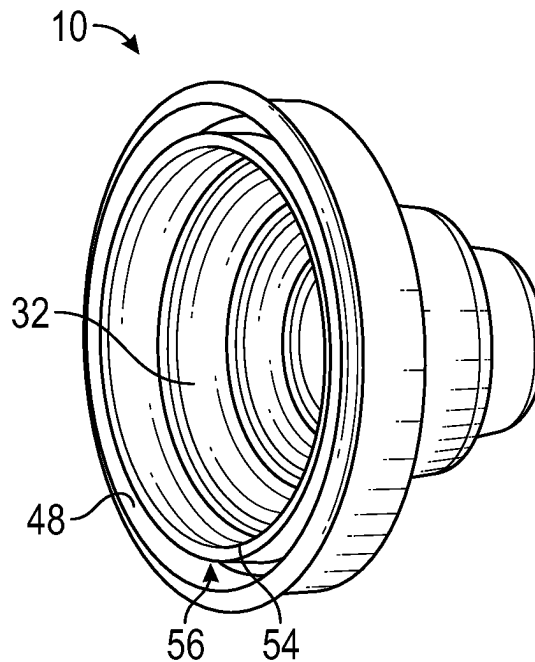


FIG. 5

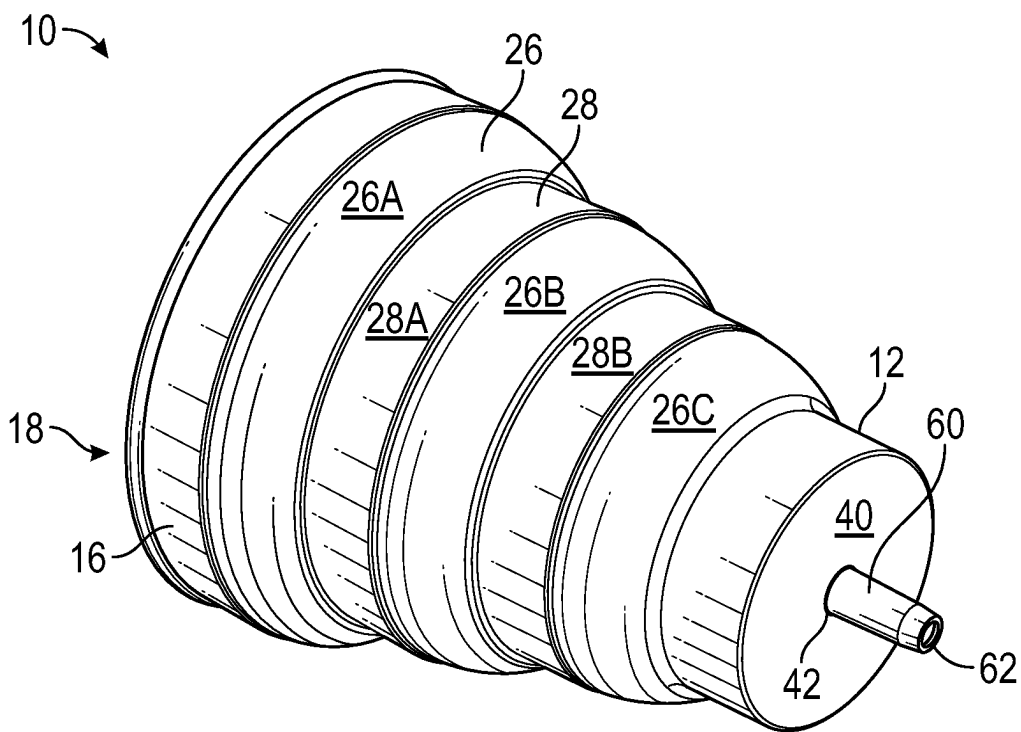


FIG. 6

COLLAPSIBLE SHIELDING DEVICE FOR SMOKING ARTICLES AND METHOD THEREFOR

TECHNICAL FIELD

[0001] The present application relates generally to smoking paraphernalia and accessories and methods and, more specifically, to smoking accessories that shield smoking articles from the wind, rain and other various weather conditions, and methods therefor.

BACKGROUND

[0002] The practice of smoking has been enjoyed by people for thousands of years. During this time, many types of plant-based substances, such as tobacco, various herbal materials, and the like, have been utilized for smoking purposes. In order to smoke these substances, various forms of smoking articles have been developed. Historical accounts indicate that some of the earliest known smoking articles included pipes from ancient civilizations. Over time, other smoking articles have been developed, including various pipes, cigars, cigarettes, electronic smoking devices, and the like.

[0003] In the past, it was common for smokers to prepare their own smoking articles by hand. Such smoking articles included, for example, hand-rolled cigarettes and other hand-rolled smoking articles, commonly referred to as “hand-rolled,” “roll-your-own,” “rollies,” “roll-ups,” and the like. These hand-rolled smoking articles were typically prepared using loose-leaf tobacco or various other loose herbal materials, which were rolled in paper to form a thin cylinder or cigarette shape. In the past, tobacco companies began mass-producing cigarettes, making ready-made industrial cigarettes available to consumers. While this obviated the need for smokers to roll their own tobacco smoking articles, even in modern times, some smokers prefer to handcraft their own smoking articles, rather than purchase ready-made smoking articles.

[0004] Some people enjoy smoking outdoors, whether to smoke ready-made, handcrafted, or other smoking articles. Oftentimes, when a smoker desires to smoke in a public space, the smoker is restricted to smoking outdoors due to governmental regulations prohibiting smoking in indoor public places. At times, there may be drawbacks to smoking outdoors, particularly during adverse weather. For example, in windy conditions, a smoker’s smoking article may be easily affected by blowing wind, which can cause the smoking article to burn too quickly, to burn hotter in some areas of the smoking article than in others, or to become extinguished, depending on the wind velocity at a given time and the form of the smoking article utilized. All of these effects can interfere with smoking and therefore be undesirable to the smoker. Hand-rolled smoking articles, in particular, may be more prone to the effects of the wind, rain or other weather elements compared to industrial smoking articles, depending on the materials used for and the quality of the preparation of the hand-rolled smoking articles. Further, in precipitous conditions, a smoker’s smoking article may be easily extinguished by rain, sleet, snow, etc. This can be undesirable to a smoker, as it can inhibit the smoker’s ability to smoke outdoors. Should the smoker attempt to smoke outdoors in such conditions, the smoker

must use a technique to protect the smoking article from the weather or cease from smoking outdoors during the adverse weather.

[0005] Various methods are known for shielding smoking articles from the wind, rain, or other weather conditions, such as a smoker turning the smoker’s back to the wind, cupping a free hand near or around the smoking article, or the like. Such methods can result in undesirable positioning of the smoker’s body, which can be uncomfortable or inconvenient. Further, cupping a free hand near or around the smoking article can occupy both hands of the smoker, as a first hand holds the smoking article while a second hand cups the smoking article in order to block the wind, rain or other weather conditions. In such a situation, the user lacks a free hand that could otherwise be used in different ways as may be needed or desired depending on the given circumstances. Other ways to shield smoking articles from the wind, rain or other weather conditions may include standing in close proximity to a wall, overhang, tree, or other structure to block the wind or other weather conditions. However, sometimes such structures may not be readily available or convenient when a smoker desires to smoke.

[0006] Therefore, it would be desirable to provide a shielding device for smoking articles that overcomes the problems discussed above. The shielding device would be able to offer protection from the wind or other weather conditions for smoking articles. The shielding device would be able to facilitate a smoker smoking during windy, rainy and/or other weather conditions as may be desired.

[0007] The present disclosure addresses the aforementioned problems as well as provides other, related advantages.

SUMMARY

[0008] In accordance with one embodiment of the present invention, a collapsible shielding device for smoking articles is disclosed. The collapsible shielding device comprises: a top portion having an opening configured to receive a portion of a smoking article therein; a bottom portion; and a body portion juxtaposed between the top portion and the bottom portion; wherein the device can be alternately positioned in a first configuration wherein the body portion is extended and a second configuration wherein the body portion is compressed.

[0009] In accordance with another embodiment of the present invention, a collapsible shielding device for smoking articles is disclosed. The collapsible shielding device comprises: a top portion having an opening configured to receive a portion of a smoking article therein; a bottom portion; and a body portion juxtaposed between the top portion and the bottom portion, wherein the body portion comprises at least one curved segment comprising an exterior portion having a convex surface and an interior portion having a concave surface, wherein the body portion is tapered in a direction toward the top portion; wherein the device can be alternately positioned in a first configuration wherein the body portion is extended and a second configuration wherein the body portion is compressed; and wherein the at least one curved segment is configured to be downwardly inverted in a direction toward the bottom portion when the device is positioned in the second configuration.

[0010] In accordance with another embodiment of the present invention, a method for shielding a smoking article is disclosed. The method comprises the steps of: providing

a collapsible shielding device for smoking articles comprising: a top portion having an opening configured to receive a portion of a smoking article therein; a bottom portion; and a body portion juxtaposed between the top portion and the bottom portion, wherein the body portion comprises at least one curved segment comprising an exterior portion having a convex surface and an interior portion having a concave surface, wherein the body portion is tapered in a direction toward the top portion; wherein the device can be alternately positioned in a first configuration wherein the body portion is extended and a second configuration wherein the body portion is compressed; and wherein the at least one curved segment is configured to be downwardly inverted in a direction toward the bottom portion when the device is positioned in the second configuration; positioning a smoking article in the opening of the top portion; extending the body portion of the device over the smoking article; lighting the smoking article; and smoking the smoking article with the smoking article in position in the device.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0011] The present application is further detailed with respect to the following drawings. These figures are not intended to limit the scope of the present application, but rather, illustrate certain attributes thereof. In the descriptions that follow, like parts are marked throughout the specification and drawings with the same numerals, respectively. The drawing figures are not necessarily drawn to scale and certain figures can be shown in exaggerated or generalized form in the interest of clarity and conciseness. The disclosure itself, however, as well as a preferred mode of use and further objectives and advantages thereof, can be best understood by reference to the following detailed description of illustrative embodiments when read in conjunction with the accompanying drawings, wherein:

[0012] FIG. 1 is a perspective view of an exemplary collapsible shielding device for smoking articles, in accordance with one aspect of the present disclosure;

[0013] FIG. 2 is a top perspective view of the collapsible shielding device of FIG. 1 in a compressed orientation, in accordance with one aspect of the present disclosure;

[0014] FIG. 3 is a bottom perspective view of the collapsible shielding device of FIG. 1 in a compressed orientation, in accordance with one aspect of the present disclosure;

[0015] FIG. 4 is a side perspective view of the collapsible shielding device of FIG. 1 in a partially extended orientation, in accordance with one aspect of the present disclosure;

[0016] FIG. 5 is a bottom perspective view of the collapsible shielding device of FIG. 1 in a partially extended orientation, in accordance with one aspect of the present disclosure; and

[0017] FIG. 6 is a perspective view of the collapsible shielding device of FIG. 1 illustrating placement of an exemplary smoking article therein, in accordance with one aspect of the present disclosure.

DESCRIPTION OF THE APPLICATION

[0018] The description set forth below in connection with the appended drawings is intended as a description of presently preferred embodiments of the disclosure and is not intended to represent the only forms in which the present disclosure can be constructed and/or utilized. The description sets forth the functions and the sequence of steps for

constructing and operating the disclosure in connection with the illustrated embodiments. It is to be understood, however, that the same or equivalent functions and sequences may be accomplished by different embodiments that are also intended to be encompassed within the spirit and scope of this disclosure.

[0019] Embodiments of the exemplary collapsible shielding device for smoking articles employ a weather-blocking technology designed to shield a smoking article from the wind, rain and/or other weather conditions. In this way, the present invention can be utilized by a user desiring to smoke a smoking article in windy, rainy, or other inclement weather conditions. Various forms of smoking articles can be used with the present invention, including ready-made smoking articles, handcrafted smoking articles, or other smoking articles, as may be desired.

[0020] The exemplary collapsible shielding device generally comprises a top portion, a body portion, and bottom portion. The top portion of the device includes an opening configured to receive a smoking article therein. The body portion can be adjustably extended over the smoking article. This can shield the smoking article, thereby allowing the user to smoke the smoking article in the wind and various inclement weather conditions. The body portion can be compressed for compact storage and ease of portability of the collapsible shielding device when not in use.

[0021] FIGS. 1-6, together, disclose embodiments of a collapsible shielding device for smoking articles **10** (hereinafter device **10**). Referring first to FIG. 1, one exemplary embodiment of the device **10** is provided. The device **10** may generally be comprised of a top portion **12**, a bottom portion **16**, and a body portion **14** juxtaposed between the top portion **12** and the bottom portion **16**. Further, the device **10** can generally have an exterior portion **46** and an interior portion **48** (see FIG. 5). In FIG. 1, the device **10** is shown in a fully-extended orientation. In this orientation, the device **10** may have a substantially cup-shaped configuration, with an open end **18** proximate the bottom portion **16** and a closed end **36** proximate the top portion **12**.

[0022] In this embodiment, the top portion **12**, body portion **14**, and bottom portion **16** of the device **10** form a one-piece assembly. In a preferred embodiment, the device **10** can be of injection-molded construction. Preferably, the device **10** is composed of a durable, flexible, material that is substantially heat-resistant, smoke-resistant, moisture-resistant and/or water-impervious, such as silicone rubber or such other suitable material as may be desired.

[0023] The bottom portion **16** can have a diameter that is greater than a diameter of the top portion **12**. The body portion **14** can have regions of varying diameters that are greater than a diameter of the top portion **12** but smaller than a diameter of the bottom portion **16**. The top portion **12** can have a diameter that is smaller than a diameter of both the bottom portion **16** and the body portion **14**.

[0024] The bottom portion **16** can include a ridge **20**. The ridge **20** can be formed around the perimeter of the bottom portion **16**. The bottom portion **16** can have a bottom sidewall **22**. The bottom sidewall **22** can extend upwardly from the ridge **20**, terminating at a lower region **24** of the body portion **14**. The bottom sidewall **22** can be oriented perpendicularly relative to a surface **40** of the top portion **12**.

[0025] The body portion **14** can be segmented and can include a plurality of segments **26** and **28**. As seen in this embodiment, each of the segments **26** can have a height that

is greater than a height of each of the segments 28. Further, the segments 26 and 28 can be of varying diameters. As seen in this embodiment, the diameters of segments 26 and 28 can progressively decrease in size from a position proximate the bottom portion 16 to a position proximate the top portion 12, such that the body portion 14 is generally tapered. In this regard, a first segment 26A can have a diameter that is greater than a diameter of an adjacent first segment 28A, the first segment 28A can have a diameter that is greater than a diameter of an adjacent second segment 26B, the second segment 26B can have a diameter that is greater than a diameter of an adjacent second segment 28B, and the second segment 28B can have a diameter that is greater than a diameter of an adjacent third segment 26C. Further, the third segment 26C can have a diameter that is greater than the diameter of the top portion 12. The first segment 26A can have a diameter that is smaller than the diameter of the bottom portion 16.

[0026] As seen in this embodiment, segments 26 can have an exterior portion 30 having a convex surface and an interior portion 32 having a concave surface (see FIG. 5). In this way, the exterior portions 30 of segments 26 can be curved/arced. Further, each segment 26 can have a diameter at a bottom portion 31 of the segment 26 that is greater than a diameter at a top portion 33 of the segment 26, such that each segment 26 is upwardly tapered in the direction of the top portion 12. With its curvature and tapering, each segment 26 is configured to be downwardly inverted in a direction toward the bottom portion 16 upon the device 10 being compressed by the user. Upon the device 10 being compressed, each segment 26 can be downwardly angled in a direction toward the bottom portion 16 (see FIG. 2). Segments 28 can have a diameter that is consistent throughout, such that each segment 28 is generally perpendicularly oriented relative to a surface 40 of the top portion 12 (as may be seen in FIG. 4). In this way, an exterior portion of each segment 28 can be substantially ring-shaped. The segments 26 and 28 can be alternating along a length of the body portion 14. In the embodiment shown, three segments 26 (26A, 26B, and 26C) and two segments 28 (28A and 28B) are provided. However, it should be understood that the number of segments 26 and 28 could deviate from these amounts to either increase or decrease an overall length of the body portion 14 of the device 10, as may be desired.

[0027] The top portion 12 can include a surface 40. The surface 40 can be substantially flat, as shown in this embodiment. The top portion 12 can include an opening 42 configured to receive a portion of a smoking article 60 (see FIG. 6) therein. Preferably, the opening 42 is sized to permit a smoking article to be inserted therein and to maintain the smoking article 60 in position during use. In an embodiment, the opening 42 can be configured to maintain the smoking article 60 therein by a press fit, interference fit, or the like. Preferably, the opening 42 is centrally positioned on the surface 40. Further, the top portion 12 can have a top sidewall 38. The top sidewall 38 can have a diameter that is consistent throughout, such that the top sidewall 38 is generally perpendicularly oriented relative to the surface 40 (see FIG. 4).

[0028] Referring now to FIG. 2, a top perspective view of the device 10 is provided, showing the device 10 in a compressed orientation. In this orientation, the device 10 can form an overall disk-like configuration. As seen in FIG. 2, when the device is positioned in this way, segments 26 can

be substantially parallel with one another. Likewise, segments 28 can be substantially parallel with one another. Further, as seen in FIG. 2, when the device 10 is in a compressed orientation, rims 50 can be formed along the exterior portion 46 of the device 10, defined by bottom portions 31 of each segment 26. According to one embodiment, rims 50 can be concentric. Further, rims 50 can be equidistantly spaced apart. Preferably, each rim 50 has a height that is equal to a height of the top portion 12, such that the surface 40 of the top portion 12 and rims 50 are coplanar when the device 10 is in a compressed orientation. While in this embodiment three rims 50 are shown, it should be understood that the number of rims 50 could deviate from this amount, depending on the number of segments 26 and, correspondingly, the overall length of the body portion 14 of the device 10, as may be desired.

[0029] Further, when the device 10 is in a compressed orientation, adjacent segments 26 and 28 can define canals 52 therebetween. The canals 52 can be formed along the exterior portion 46 of the device 10. According to one embodiment, canals 52 can be concentric. Further, canals 52 can be equidistantly spaced apart. Preferably, each canal 52 has a dimension that is no greater than a height of the bottom portion 16. As seen in FIG. 2, two canals 52 are formed by adjacent segments 26 and 28. Further, an additional canal 52A can be seen, defined by an uppermost segment 26C and the top sidewall 38. While in this embodiment a total of three canals 52 and 52A are shown, it should be understood that the number of canals 52 and 52A could deviate from this amount, depending on the number of segments 26 and, correspondingly, the overall length of the body portion 14 of the device 10, as may be desired.

[0030] Referring now to FIG. 3, a bottom perspective view of the device 10 in a compressed orientation is provided. In this embodiment, the interior portion 48 of the device 10 can be seen. As seen in FIG. 3, when the device 10 is in a compressed orientation, an interior portion of each canal 52 defines an interior rim 54, while an interior portion of each rim 50 defines an interior canal 56. According to one embodiment, interior rims 54 can be concentric, similar to rims 50 (see FIG. 2). Further, interior rims 54 can be equidistantly spaced apart, similar to rims 50 (see FIG. 2). Preferably, each interior rim 54 extends no further than the ridge 20 of the bottom portion 16, such that the interior rims 54 and ridge 20 are substantially coplanar when the device 10 is in a compressed orientation (see FIG. 3). While in this embodiment three interior rims 54 are shown, it should be understood that the number of interior rims 54 could deviate from this amount, depending on the number of segments 26 and, correspondingly, the overall length of the body portion 14 of the device 10, as may be desired. Further, when the device 10 is in a compressed orientation, an interior portion of each rim 50 defines an interior canal 56. According to one embodiment, interior canals 56 can be concentric, similar to canals 52 (see FIG. 2). Further, interior canals 56 can be equidistantly spaced apart, similar to canals 52 (see FIG. 2). Preferably, each interior canal 56 has a depth that is no greater than a height of the top portion 12, such that the surface 40 of the top portion 12 and interior canals 56 are substantially coplanar when the device 10 is in a compressed orientation. While in this embodiment a total of three interior canals 56 are shown, it should be understood that the number of interior canals 56 could deviate from this amount,

depending on the number of segments **26** and, correspondingly, the overall length of the body portion **14** of the device **10**, as may be desired.

[0031] Referring now to FIG. 4, a side view of the device **10** is provided, showing the device **10** in a partially extended orientation. In this orientation, segment **26A** is shown in a compressed state, such that segment **26A** is angled downwardly in a direction toward the bottom portion **16**. In this way, the overall height of the device **10** can be decreased relative to an overall height of the device **10** when in a fully extended orientation (see FIG. 1), which may be desired depending on a length of a smoking article to be smoked by a user of the device **10**. FIG. 5 is a bottom perspective view of the device **10** shown in a partially extended orientation. As can be seen in FIG. 5, in the partially extended orientation shown, one interior canal **56** and one interior rim **54** can be provided. While the views in FIGS. 4 and 5 are referred to as showing the device **10** partially extended, it should be understood that the device **10** can also be referred to as being partially compressed in these views.

[0032] Referring now to FIG. 6, a perspective view of the device **10** is shown, illustrating an exemplary smoking article **60** positioned in the device **10**. The smoking article **60** can have a mouth end **62** that is configured to be inserted into a person's mouth and a burn end (not shown) that is configured to be ignited in order to generate smoke to be inhaled by the person.

[0033] The device **10** is adapted to be positioned in multiple configurations. According to one embodiment, in a first configuration, as demonstrated in FIGS. 1 and 6, the device **10** can be extended to a maximum length, revealing five segments **26** and **28** collectively, which may be suitable for smoking various smoking articles having a length corresponding to the maximum length of the device **10** shown, for example. According to one embodiment, in a second configuration, as demonstrated in FIGS. 4 and 5, the device **10** can be partially extended, revealing three segments **26** and **28** collectively, which may be suitable for smoking various smoking articles having a length corresponding to the length of the device **10** shown partially extended, for example. While three segments **26** and **28** are exposed in this second configuration, it should be understood that the device **10** may be adjusted to expose more than three or less than three segments **26** and **28** collectively, as may be desired, depending on the length of the particular smoking article to be utilized with the device **10**. According to one embodiment, in a third configuration, as demonstrated in FIGS. 2 and 3, the device **10** can be compressed, forming an overall disk-like configuration. In this third configuration, the device **10** is of a relative minimum height, which may be suitable for easily storing and/or carrying the device **10** when not in use, such as by storing in a pocket, backpack, purse, drawer, or such other suitable storage device as may be desired. In this third configuration, segments **28** are configured to nest between adjacent segments **26**. Preferably, in this third configuration, surface **40** of the top portion **12** is coplanar with rims **50** (as seen in FIG. 2), while interior rims **54** are coplanar with one another (as seen in FIG. 3).

Statement of Operation

[0034] In order to use the device **10** so that it can shield smoking articles from the wind, rain, or other adverse weather conditions, a user **70** would first hold the device **10** in the compressed orientation (see FIG. 3). With the open

end **18** of the device **10** (see FIG. 3) facing the user, the user could then insert a mouth end **62** of a smoking article **60** into the opening **42** so that the mouth end **62** protrudes from the top portion **12** of the device **10** (see FIG. 6). The user could then adjust the length of the device **10** to accommodate the smoking article **60** by grasping the bottom portion **16** of the device **10** and pulling the bottom portion **16** in a direction away from the top portion **12**, extending one or more segments **26** and/or **28** of the device **10** to accommodate a length of the smoking article **60** to be smoked. Preferably, the bottom portion **16** of the device **10** would be extended beyond the burn end (not shown) of the smoking article to be smoked; however, it would be possible to extend the device **10** to various other lengths, as may be desired. The user could then light the smoking article and proceed to smoke. During windy conditions, the user would hold the device **10** in a direction away from the wind while smoking. Preferably, the user would light the smoking article after positioning the smoking article in the device **10**; however, it would be possible to light the smoking article first and then insert it into the device **10**.

[0035] The foregoing description is illustrative of particular embodiments of the application, but is not meant to be a limitation upon the practice thereof. The following claims, including all equivalents thereof, are intended to define the scope of the application.

What is claimed is:

1. A collapsible shielding device for smoking articles comprising:

- a top portion having an opening configured to receive a portion of a smoking article therein;
- a bottom portion; and
- a body portion juxtaposed between the top portion and the bottom portion;

wherein the device can be alternately positioned in a first configuration wherein the body portion is extended and a second configuration wherein the body portion is compressed.

2. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 1 wherein the body portion comprises at least one curved segment comprising an exterior portion having a convex surface and an interior portion having a concave surface, wherein the at least one curved segment is configured to be downwardly inverted in a direction toward the bottom portion when the device is positioned in the second configuration.

3. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 1 wherein the body portion comprises a plurality of segments, the plurality of segments comprising:

- at least one curved segment comprising an exterior portion having a convex surface and an interior portion having a concave surface, wherein the at least one curved segment is configured to be downwardly inverted in a direction toward the bottom portion when the device is positioned in the second configuration; and

at least one ring-shaped segment perpendicularly oriented relative to a surface of the top portion.

4. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 3 wherein the plurality of segments comprises three curved segments and two ring-shaped segments.

5. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 4 wherein the curved segments and the ring-shaped segments alternate along a length of the body portion.

6. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 4 wherein:

- a first curved segment is positioned proximate the bottom portion;
- a first ring-shaped segment is positioned adjacent to the first curved segment and has a diameter less than a diameter of the first curved segment;
- a second curved segment is positioned adjacent to the first ring-shaped segment and has a diameter less than the diameter of the first ring-shaped segment;
- a second ring-shaped segment is positioned adjacent to the second curved segment and has a diameter less than a diameter of the second curved segment; and
- a third curved segment is positioned adjacent to the second ring-shaped segment and has a diameter less than the diameter of the second ring-shaped segment.

7. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 1 wherein the device can be alternately positioned in a third configuration wherein the body portion is partially extended.

8. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 1 wherein the body portion is tapered in a direction toward the top portion.

9. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 1 further comprising a ridge around a perimeter of the bottom portion.

10. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 1 further comprising a plurality of concentric rims formed along the body portion when the device is positioned in the second configuration.

11. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 1 comprised of silicone rubber material.

12. A collapsible shielding device for smoking articles comprising:

- a top portion having an opening configured to receive a portion of a smoking article therein;
 - a bottom portion; and
 - a body portion juxtaposed between the top portion and the bottom portion, wherein the body portion comprises at least one curved segment comprising an exterior portion having a convex surface and an interior portion having a concave surface, wherein the body portion is tapered in a direction toward the top portion;
- wherein the device can be alternately positioned in a first configuration wherein the body portion is extended and a second configuration wherein the body portion is compressed; and
- wherein the at least one curved segment is configured to be downwardly inverted in a direction toward the bottom portion when the device is positioned in the second configuration.

13. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 12 wherein the body portion further comprises at least one ring-shaped segment perpendicularly oriented relative to a surface of the top portion.

14. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 12 wherein the body portion comprises a plurality of segments, the plurality of segments comprising the at least one curved segment and at least one ring-shaped segment perpendicularly oriented relative to a surface of the top portion.

15. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 14 wherein the plurality of segments comprises three curved segments and two ring-shaped segments, wherein the curved segments and the ring-shaped segments alternate along a length of the body portion.

16. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 15 wherein:

- a first curved segment is positioned proximate the bottom portion;
- a first ring-shaped segment is positioned adjacent to the first curved segment and has a diameter less than a diameter of the first curved segment;
- a second curved segment is positioned adjacent to the first ring-shaped segment and has a diameter less than the diameter of the first ring-shaped segment;
- a second ring-shaped segment is positioned adjacent to the second curved segment and has a diameter less than a diameter of the second curved segment; and
- a third curved segment is positioned adjacent to the second ring-shaped segment and has a diameter less than the diameter of the second ring-shaped segment.

17. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 12 wherein the device can be alternately positioned in a third configuration wherein the body portion is partially extended.

18. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 12 further comprising a ridge around a perimeter of the bottom portion.

19. The collapsible shielding device for smoking articles of claim 1 comprised of silicone rubber material.

20. A method for shielding a smoking article comprising: providing a collapsible shielding device for smoking articles comprising:

- a top portion having an opening configured to receive a portion of a smoking article therein;
 - a bottom portion; and
 - a body portion juxtaposed between the top portion and the bottom portion, wherein the body portion comprises at least one curved segment comprising an exterior portion having a convex surface and an interior portion having a concave surface, wherein the body portion is tapered in a direction toward the top portion;
- wherein the device can be alternately positioned in a first configuration wherein the body portion is extended and a second configuration wherein the body portion is compressed; and
- wherein the at least one curved segment is configured to be downwardly inverted in a direction toward the bottom portion when the device is positioned in the second configuration;

positioning a smoking article in the opening of the top portion;

extending the body portion of the device over the smoking article;

lighting the smoking article; and

smoking the smoking article with the smoking article in position in the device.

* * * * *